FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



The present moment is one where the world is sharply polarised by war, weaponised tariffs and shifting power centres. At such a time, Russian president Vladimir Putin's interview to the India Today TV team of Anjana Om Kashyap and Geeta Mohan at the Kremlin, on the eve of his New Delhi visit, is a rare exclusive. It offers a front-row view of how one of the world's longest-serving and most controversial leaders sees India, the West, and the emerging global order. What struck me was the contrast between the stereotype of Putin and the leader in person. The projected image is that of an unsmiling autocrat, ruthlessly wedded to power and not open to questioning. In the flesh, he's an animated and engaging talker, with an expressive face, an array of gestures and a subtle sense of humour. There were no red lines from his team, and he let what was supposed to be a 60-minute session run to 100 minutes. Later, he had an informal chat with the Group's Editorial Team, which I was part of.

Even when Putin talks of the contemporary world, it's deepened by his keen sense of history. You may not always agree with his worldview, but he has a knack for the grander thesis. On the India-Russia relationship, for instance, he does not go into why this visit to New Delhi has taken so long. It's his first in four years, and the interregnum had seen relations between the two drift apart for a while. Instead, Putin began the interview by ticking all the necessary boxes. He spoke of "solidarity, camaraderie and friendship", as well as practical ideas for positioning the ties to look ahead in key domains such as "artificial intelligence, cutting-edge defence technology and advanced nuclear reactors". He lavished high praise on his host, saying: "Prime Minister Modi is not someone who succumbs to pressure easily." He took a swipe at America's double standards in penalising India for buying Russian oil. "The US still buys uranium fuel from Russia to run its nuclear plants. If the US has the right to buy our fuel, shouldn't India have the same privilege?" he asked. The problem with the imbalanced rupee-rouble trade, he insists, was not politics but economics, adding that he had sent out a diktat to Russian business to find enough Indian goods it genuinely wants to import.



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On the new world order, Putin is openly dismissive of a return to the G8 and questions the continued dominance of the G7 when countries like India now rank far higher in purchasing power. "Why would I go to G7? Nobody talks to me," he told INDIA TODAY. He sees real momentum instead in platforms like BRICS, the SCO and the larger Global South. Wisely, however, he cautions against "rushing into" a BRICS currency, arguing instead for wider use of national currencies and electronic payment systems. Putin sees India not just as a legacy ally, but as a central player of these emerging power centres that are reshaping global trade, finance and technology. On India-China tensions, he was diplomatic, calling both "our closest friends" and insisting that Russia will not interfere even while praising the "wisdom" of Modi and Xi Jinping for their recent efforts to manage disputes.

The interview turned combative when it came to the Ukraine war, with Putin offering a lengthy justification, portraying Russia's actions as the defence of Russian-speaking populations, traditional values, language and the Orthodox Church. He blames the West for backing a coup in Kyiv, claiming Russia tried for eight years to resolve differences with Ukraine through the Minsk Agreements, and insists that the "special military operation" is an attempt to end, not start, a war. NATO's eastward expansion, he argues, violated assurances given to Moscow and created an intolerable security threat. Russia, he says, will end the war only when its goals of "liberating territories" and securing its interests are achieved. He comes across as a man betrayed by the West. If America thinks sanctions will bring Russia to its knees, it could be in for a shock. In Moscow, what I saw was not an economy in distress. In today's globalised world, goods find their way through intermediaries wherever demand exists. The shops are laden with foreign